

Chapter 103-1

Her gentle voice was as if dipped in honey. When singing a cappella, it sounded like someone who had just woken up—tender and delicate.

"See the moon like the pupil of the night sky

Quietly gazing at you and me and our clamoring planet."

Xu Qingzhu had also heard this song before. Liang Shi was considerate to the extreme.

When she made a request, Liang Shi would comply without even asking why or bargaining with her.

At this moment, Xu Qingzhu had no doubt that if she asked for something else, Liang Shi would also do it without hesitation.

No matter what she asked for.

Liang Shi trusted her completely.

It was only later when Xu Qingzhu looked it up that she learned what kissing someone's instep meant.

The internet said—kissing the instep meant submission.

That day it had been something she did while drunk. Although it couldn't be taken seriously, it made the one who tended to overthink toss and turn sleeplessly for several nights.

Even if on the surface she appeared calm and indifferent to favor or disgrace, in her heart there were surging waves that could rise at any moment. Even after several days had passed, just thinking about it would still make her ears turn slightly red.

After all, it was an experience that made one's tailbone tingle. The sensation was too vivid, making it too unforgettable.

Perhaps darkness made people bolder, allowing them not to be bound by rules.

Xu Qingzhu gently bit Liang Shi's neck, biting right where she made sound, causing Liang Shi's singing voice to break off.

When you like someone, you always unconsciously want to get closer and press against them.

The slower this process, the more captivating it becomes.

This was probably the psychology of delayed gratification—the slower you obtain what you want most, the more you'll cherish it and find it unforgettable and precious.

If something is too easily obtained, it always feels too cheap and too easy.

With someone you like, you don't need to be pressed close together for long. A hug, or a brief touch of fingers, can feel like electricity.

Xu Qingzhu's slender pale fingers undid the last button of Liang Shi's nightgown, and it fell completely loose.

The melody Liang Shi sang a cappella was easy to follow, but her voice was also restrained.

Xu Qingzhu released her and unconsciously hummed along with the melody.

"Getting close to you, why are we both suddenly at a loss for words

Making heartbeats surge like wildfire spreading across the plains."

Her voice was cool, yet at this moment it was tinged with the same tenderness as Liang Shi's.

Liang Shi smiled helplessly, not quite understanding this preference of hers, yet her voice made her heart itch, like a feather gently tickling the tip of her heart.

This wasn't a continuous feeling—it was like an ancient torture method, scratching at the places you're most afraid of being tickled, trapping you there unable to move, yet powerless to do anything.

The difference between the two was that torture made people afraid, unwilling for it to happen again.

But this kind of feeling was like waves that could crash in from the sea at any moment, making your heart itch yet constantly anticipating them.

The red spreading from the corners of Liang Shi's eyes was so beautiful it seemed unreal, like the crimson clouds at dusk.

Not falling on the horizon or into the sunset, but falling into her light brown eyes.

Those eyes were as bright as ever, yet more captivating than usual.

Liang Shi lay on her side, close to Xu Qingzhu, her voice low and husky, overlapping with Xu Qingzhu's voice in the air.

The cool voice and the gentle voice blended together without any discord.

The two different voices merged perfectly, sounding like a clear stream flowing peacefully through a valley, passing mountains and rivers, merging into the sea.

A gentle stream made one feel peaceful, tender, and comfortable.

The lyrics were also fitting for the moment. Both of them wore smiles, and even Xu Qingzhu's usually cool eyes were now tinged with warmth.

Liang Shi tried hard to match Xu Qingzhu's singing rhythm, finally falling in step with her.

"In this moment, let even fate fall silent

Let our toes glide across sky and sky, earth and earth

The universe of destiny."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly let out a soft laugh, burying her head in the crook of Liang Shi's shoulder. The hair at her temples was already a bit damp, yet she laughed foolishly, laughing until her whole body shook, which made Liang Shi's voice tremble too.

Liang Shi was helpless. She stopped but didn't dare speak.

Liang Shi's fingers were beautiful, and she didn't like to keep long nails. Her hands were slender and long, without even calluses on her fingernails.

Xu Qingzhu had compared them before while holding her hand. She didn't know if Alpha hands naturally had an advantage over Omega hands, or if it was because Liang Shi was tall, but her hands were a size larger than Xu Qingzhu's, and even her fingers were a segment longer—about the length of a fingernail.

But they were both women, and Xu Qingzhu was only a few centimeters shorter than her, so that fingernail-length difference seemed like a lot.

They had never interlocked fingers before.

Though Liang Shi had held Xu Qingzhu's hand, palm to palm overlapping, walking together for long distances.

They had also strolled by the seaside, hands tightly clasped while watching the ocean.

But Liang Shi wasn't someone who dared to hold hands easily. Every time she first held someone's hand, her grip was very loose, even hovering in the air. Xu Qingzhu always had to move closer before she could hold on tightly.

It was as if she had to muster great courage.

Xu Qingzhu's thoughts gradually drifted. Suddenly, there was a loud clap of thunder outside, pulling her scattered thoughts back together.

Her hand suddenly fell on Liang Shi's free hand, interlocking their fingers.

Xu Qingzhu nestled in Liang Shi's embrace.

Liang Shi's voice was infinitely amplified by her ear, slowing down as she sang the last line, "Seven, eight, nine—we elope to the moon."¹

So gentle that it made you willing to accompany her to the end of the universe.

And without any hesitation.

1. This is the final line from the song "私奔到月球" (Elope to the Moon) by Mayday featuring Cheer Chen. The "seven, eight, nine" (七八九) is a countdown in the song leading to the romantic declaration of eloping to the moon together. The song is about two people wanting to escape the world together and find their own private paradise on the moon.

Chapter 103-2

&&

The late autumn rain pattered down, blown by the wind to fall lingeringly on the windows. The fine, dense raindrops gathered into streams on the transparent glass, meandering across.

Water droplets condensed on the metal railing, drip-drop, drip-drop, falling straight down from above.

On the distant mountains was a mist that wouldn't disperse. The far horizon was covered by dark, oppressive clouds.

The withered yellow leaves were all shaken from the trees by the wind. The autumn breeze swept the dampened fallen leaves toward some unknown distant place.

The dark gray curtains matched the sky. Faint light refracted through the rain-covered glass windows, falling on the bed.

Unlike sunny weather, where light could make one feel lazy.

The light on gloomy days carried a stifling quality, yet it easily made one want to surrender.

Just wanting to keep falling in this dimness.

Whether below lay an unfathomably deep abyss or a boundless deep sea.

The faint, almost nonexistent light shone into the room. The sounds were scattered into fragments by the wind outside the window. Soft whimpers dispersed into every corner of the room.

.....

The rain didn't stop until nearly noon.

The clouds parted and the mist dispersed. The cold sun broke through the dark, oppressive cloud layer and scattered down to the world.

The busy traffic on the roads continued as usual. Pedestrians on both banks of the river put away their umbrellas. The river water rose and fell. The city, washed by the light rain, carried the coolness unique to autumn, and even the air became fresh.

Liang Shi pulled open the curtains, and the cold sunlight poured into the room.

Xu Qingzhu was still lying on the bed, eyes half-closed, her fine, soft black hair spread on the pillow. Liang Shi stood backlit, her silhouette slender—a pleasing sight to behold.

Xu Qingzhu pulled her arms back under the covers, wrapping herself up tightly. Only the strawberry marks on her neck couldn't be hidden.

She reached up to press the tingling spot on her neck, the corners of her lips slightly raised.

This day didn't seem so gloomy after all.

At least one's mood was exceptionally good.

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice rang out in the room. "Liang Shi."

When she called Liang Shi's name, the ending tone rose upward, carrying a hint of joy and pleasure, even though the syllable "Shi" was more suited to going down.

But she insisted on raising it.

Liang Shi turned around. Her long hair was casually tied up in a loose ponytail, resting on her back.

She had already changed into a different set of nightclothes. The previous set had been thrown into the dirty laundry basket in Xu Qingzhu's room, piled together with Xu Qingzhu's clothes.

Along with Xu Qingzhu's clothes, all piled together, to be thrown into the washing machine later.

Both of them seemed to have slight cleanliness tendencies, but when it came to each other, it wasn't that serious.

Liang Shi could share Xu Qingzhu's things, and had even bitten into food that Xu Qingzhu had half-eaten.

Perhaps after intimate contact, one would include the other person within one's acceptable range.

So clothes could also be washed in the same washing machine.

One person didn't have that many clothes to wash, but with two people's clothes together, it was just the right amount for one load.

Initially, Liang Shi had suggested this to conserve water, and Xu Qingzhu had no objections.

Hearing Xu Qingzhu call her, Liang Shi turned around and responded with an "mm," then sat down on the bay window, shaking her arms. Like playing piano, her fingers curled and uncurled in the air.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and asked in a low voice, "Tired?"

Liang Shi: "....."

After sitting on the bay window, her long legs had nowhere to go and just rested casually on the floor.

After hearing Xu Qingzhu ask this, Liang Shi immediately withdrew her hands, resting them on the bay window to support herself. She smiled. "What's there to be tired about?"

"I'm tired." Xu Qingzhu said, her voice very soft. But there was no more rain outside, only the sound of water flowing through the pipes past the window, not quite audible, so it wouldn't drown out Xu Qingzhu's voice.

With the light now present, Liang Shi felt slightly unnatural. She didn't look directly at her face, and even the tips of her ears were a bit red.

Almost without hesitation, Liang Shi subconsciously asked, "Where are you tired?"

Xu Qingzhu: ".....Everywhere."

Liang Shi: "....."

Awkwardness spread instantly. Yet after her mind went blank, Liang Shi asked, "Want me to give you a massage?"

Xu Qingzhu buried half her head in the covers and laughed softly. "No need."

Liang Shi's expression was somewhat wooden, even a bit dazed. Two seconds later, she lowered her head and smiled helplessly. "Xu Qingzhu....."

Having been silent for so long without saying long sentences, her throat felt a bit uncomfortable when she spoke. She rubbed her throat, which still seemed to retain a damp, warm sensation from being sucked and bitten.

Bullied to the point of not knowing what to do.

There was no other way but to indulge her.

Including finding all her behaviors amusing.

She had bitten someone, yet still liked to ask in a hoarse voice, "Does it feel good? Do you like it?"

When Liang Shi didn't respond, she would continue calling, "Teacher Liang?"

Calling until the person was at a loss, not knowing whether to answer or not.

Although Liang Shi was a few years older than her, she wasn't as bold.

Growing in age but not in courage.

To be precise, Liang Shi didn't dare and couldn't let go.

But Xu Qingzhu insisted on keeping herself physically and mentally pleased, bravely saying no to things she didn't like. So she was bold, because she preferred to make herself happy.

Yet she also didn't forget about Liang Shi.

Liang Shi didn't answer and kept silent, but her throat felt like it was going through tribulation.

When she got up, she used her phone's front camera to check. The deadly angle made her neck look like she had gone through a tropical jungle, bitten all over by giant mosquitoes.¹

Even though it had already ended quite a while ago, Liang Shi's voice was still a bit uncomfortable when speaking. She said to her, "Stop teasing me."

Xu Qingzhu obediently closed her eyes and pretended to sleep, letting the cold sun after the rain shine on her face. Her fair skin was delicate as if it could be broken by a breath, still carrying a rosy flush, like a thin layer of blush had been applied to her cheeks.

Liang Shi watched her for a while, unconsciously spacing out for a moment, before finally standing up and asking what she wanted to eat.

-
1. This is a humorous euphemism. "Strawberry marks" (草莓印) and the comparison to "mosquito bites" are both common Chinese slang terms for hickeys/love bites. ⇐

Chapter 103-3

Xu Qingzhu said, "Anything is fine."

Liang Shi rolled up her sleeves, revealing her fair arms. As she was walking out, she was stopped by Xu Qingzhu calling her. "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi's footsteps paused at the doorway. She turned around and responded softly, "Hm?"

"Come here." The lower half of Xu Qingzhu's face was still buried in the covers, her voice husky. Those eyes carried a tender languor after being satisfied.

Just two simple words, without any commanding tone—it even felt like she was acting spoiled.

After all, those eyes revealed gentle affection.

Those eyes were languid and casual. After she spoke, as if afraid Liang Shi would refuse, she added, "Come here."

Her cool voice carried a laziness that made one unconsciously want to submit.

Liang Shi walked over, thinking something was wrong with her body. She bent down and asked, "What's wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu's eyes curved slightly. "Guess?"

Liang Shi: "....."

It was only recently that she had discovered Xu Qingzhu particularly liked to tease people.

Probably because they had become familiar with each other, she had discovered this trait in her personality and now took pleasure in teasing her.

Liang Shi said helplessly, "Aren't you hungry?"

"I am hungry." Xu Qingzhu said.

After going through all that, how could she not be tired?

"Then I'll go make food." Liang Shi said. "You rest well."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, then suddenly reached out a hand and grabbed the collar of Liang Shi's nightgown. The silk nightgown was tightly clutched in her palm, crumpled into a ball.

Liang Shi's body also leaned forward with gravity, and their eyes met.

Her figure was reflected in those beautiful eyes. Xu Qingzhu moved closer and bit her lips once.

Then instantly pulled away.

Liang Shi was stunned. Before she could react, Xu Qingzhu sat up and wrapped both arms around her neck.

Xu Qingzhu whispered by her ear, "Liang Shi, I need a hug."

Chapter 103-4

&&

When Liang Shi arrived at the kitchen, her heartbeat still hadn't returned to normal speed.

The two words "a hug" spoken by Xu Qingzhu were enough to make one's heart race.

And Xu Qingzhu had even kissed her on the cheek.

Xu Qingzhu said she needed a hug.

The formal word for "embrace" wasn't enough to share the joy she had received, but the cutesy "hug" could.¹

That tender, gentle voice made one's heart beat rapidly and non-stop, as if the whole person was about to explode on the spot.

In her mind, it was like New Year's, with firecrackers popping and crackling, yet it didn't feel noisy at all.

Only joy.

A comfortable joy.

Liang Shi leaned against the cold wall of the kitchen, resting her head against it too.

But the coldness didn't cool down her body. She pressed her hand over her heart, wanting it to quickly return to a normal heartbeat.

It was difficult.

Xu Qingzhu's voice echoed in her ears again and again.

Liang Shi couldn't calm down enough to cook.

So she chose to eat out, and sent a phone message to Xu Qingzhu: 【Get up.】

Two words that looked particularly cold, without a hint of warmth.

So Liang Shi added another line: 【Let's go eat downstairs.】

Without a sentence-final particle, this sentence would also seem cold, but adding a "ba" instantly changed the attitude.²

Liang Shi stared at the screen, and a few seconds later sent another message: 【Xu Qingzhu, let's go.】

This "ya" particle added a few more degrees of warmth, as if showing vulnerability.²

However, above the message, what was originally the contact name "Xu Qingzhu" had suddenly changed to "The other party is typing."

This typing lasted five seconds. Liang Shi stared intently at the screen, waiting for her reply.

But suddenly, Xu Qingzhu's voice came from the master bedroom. "Teacher Liang, don't you think this apartment is especially big?"

Her voice was lazy, not loud, with a casual air.

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu was wearing a white spaghetti-strap nightgown, her shoulders exposed. Her slender, fair forearm rested on the door frame, her fine, soft long hair cascading down.

She was barefoot, with everything below her knees uncovered.

Xu Qingzhu leaned casually against the door, and her gaze happened to meet Liang Shi's as she walked out of the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu had a smile at the corner of her lips, the corners of her eyes tilted upward. "It's only a few steps away. Do you need to use your phone?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi's gaze darted everywhere—she just didn't dare look at her.

Clearly she was the one who should be considered at a disadvantage, yet she was so at ease that it made Liang Shi feel awkward.

"Don't you want to talk to me anymore?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: ".....No."

Liang Shi said it without much conviction. She felt she urgently needed to go outside for some fresh air, to change the environment.

If she stayed in this space any longer, she would probably suffocate to death or die from a racing heart.

"Jiejie."³ Xu Qingzhu's voice was light, already returned to normal, yet it still made Liang Shi's heart skip a beat.

It was as if she had heard this voice somewhere before.

The same way of calling, even the pause in the middle was the same—always liking to break in the middle.

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu in surprise, but her eyes immediately caught sight of Xu Qingzhu's bare feet.

The fair feet formed a stark contrast with the natural wood-colored floor.

It was a very beautiful scene, even quite artistic.

It could be appreciated as a painting.

But for Liang Shi, her first reaction was—the floor didn't have heating yet, she would catch a cold.

In spring and autumn, one shouldn't walk barefoot on the floor.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and repeated, "Jiejie, can you give me something to eat? I want to eat at home."

Liang Shi: "....."

She pressed her lips together. "Go back to the room and wait."

Xu Qingzhu: "Okay."

Yet she still stood there without moving.

Liang Shi didn't move either. After a few seconds of eye contact, it was ultimately Liang Shi who gave in. She walked back to the master bedroom, passed right by Xu Qingzhu, got her slippers and placed them by her feet, then half-crouched down and said in a low voice, "Lift your foot."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She lowered her eyes, swallowed, and lifted her foot slightly.

Liang Shi patiently helped her put on the slippers, just like she usually did with Ling Dang.

No, even more attentively than that.

She didn't treat her any differently just because she was an adult.

But when Liang Shi stood up, Xu Qingzhu suddenly grabbed her wrist. Her fingertip rubbed against her pulse point and felt her racing heartbeat.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly laughed softly. "Teacher Liang, your heart beats this fast just from helping me put on shoes?"

Liang Shi: ".....No."

Her denial had no persuasive power in the face of her accelerating heartbeat.

But she wanted to leave, to escape from this environment that left her at a loss. Yet she was held back by Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi asked in a low voice, "Are you going to eat or not?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled. "Yes."

Liang Shi: "Then let go."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly reached out with her free arm, pulled her down directly, then stood on tiptoe and kissed her on the lips.

It wasn't a very lingering kiss, nor were there any excessive movements.

It ended quickly.

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the door and smiled, with a hint of mischief. "Teacher Liang, is your heart beating fast now?"

1. In Chinese, "擁抱" (yōngbào) is the formal word for "embrace/hug," while "抱抱" (bàobao) is a cutesy, reduplicated form that sounds more affectionate and childlike, similar to saying "huggy" or "gimme a hug" in English. ↵
2. Chinese sentence-final particles like "吧" (ba) and "呀" (ya) add nuance to sentences. "吧" softens a statement into a suggestion, while "呀" adds a friendly, gentle, or slightly pleading tone. Without these particles, sentences can sound blunt or cold. ↵ ↵²
3. "Jiejie" (姐姐) means "older sister" in Chinese. It's used here as an intimate term of address, which is particularly significant given the context of their relationship. Xu Qingzhu calling Liang Shi "jiejie" carries romantic and affectionate undertones. ↵

Chapter 103-5

.....

&&

Liang Shi cooked noodles at noon, her whole person like a crab amid the rising steam.

However, Xu Qingzhu's call of "jiejie" kept making her lose focus.

She always felt like she had heard it somewhere before, but couldn't remember where.

In the end, she attributed it to the fact that perhaps because Xu Qingzhu had said it so seriously, when it reached her ears she had unconsciously added a romantic overtone to it, which was why she found it unforgettable.

Xu Qingzhu ate more than usual at noon. Liang Shi ate slowly and kept looking at her fingers while eating.

No one knew what she was thinking about.

She and Xu Qingzhu took turns washing up, and it wasn't until past two in the afternoon that they finally went out.

The immersive escape room they had booked was quite far away—it took over forty minutes to drive there, in another city center.

On the way there, Liang Shi drove while Xu Qingzhu sat in the passenger seat.

Somehow, the car's music first played the song Liang Shi had sung last night. Xu Qingzhu half-closed her eyes and hummed along softly to the melody.

After a while, the music in the car started playing "Elope to the Moon."

It made one unconsciously think of the scene from this morning.

Liang Shi's face turned a bit red again. Xu Qingzhu looked at her, noticing all her little movements and thoughts, but didn't call her out or say anything.

It wasn't until they arrived at the escape room shop that Xu Qingzhu leaned close to her when getting out of the car and said, "Teacher Liang."

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

Xu Qingzhu's voice was very soft, audible only to the two of them.

"Leave what happened at home at home." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "?"

"Don't think east, think west, think south, think north, thinking this way and that~" Xu Qingzhu's pitch rose slightly, her tone melodious, almost enunciating word by word: "Over. Think. Ing."¹

Liang Shi: "....."

East, west, south, north—put together, it was very similar to the cheesy pickup line Liang Shi had used on her this morning.

Yet she had to say it in such a roundabout way, making Liang Shi's ears turn red.

Liang Shi said stubbornly, "I didn't say anything, and I wasn't thinking about anything."

Xu Qingzhu drew out a long "oh" sound, then continued walking forward.

Liang Shi: "....."

She felt like that sentence was really saying—forget what happened in bed, don't overthink it, I'm not taking it to heart.

At first, Liang Shi felt a bit uncomfortable in her heart, though she couldn't pinpoint exactly what was uncomfortable. She had been thinking about it, but when they entered the escape room shop, she put all those thoughts aside.

Xu Qingzhu picked a scenario with her and asked what she wanted to play.

Liang Shi looked at all the pictures hanging in the shop and finally chose the pink-themed escape room.

The theme of the room was—Fantasy Castle.

Xu Qingzhu smiled and said, "Are you scared?"

Liang Shi: ".....I'm scared that you'll be scared."

At this moment, Liang Shi had absolutely no idea that the experience of immersive escape rooms was—the pinker it looks, the more intense the gameplay.

1. This is a callback to the cheesy pickup line from Chapter 102. Liang Shi's joke involved the directions East (东), West (西), South (南), North (北) to spell out "baby" (北鼻). Here, Xu Qingzhu playfully uses the same directional framework: "东想" (think east), "西想" (think west), "南想" (think south), "北想" (think north), which together sounds like "胡思乱想" (húsī luànxiǎng), meaning "to overthink" or "to let one's imagination run wild." She's teasing Liang Shi for being distracted by thoughts of their intimate moments. ⇐